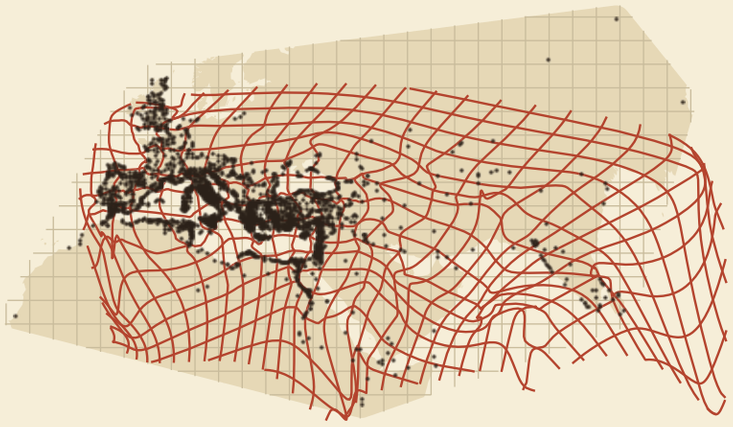
Eight old maps, bent to fit the real world

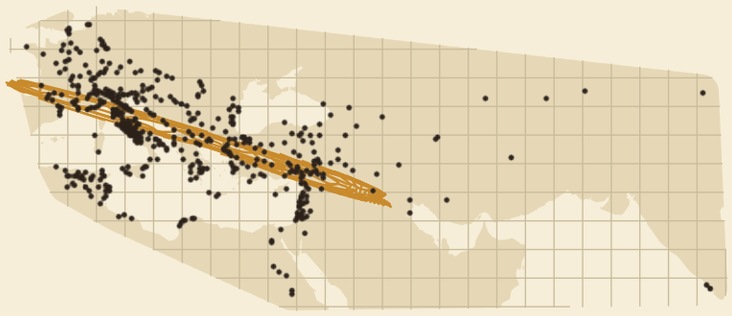
Grey: a regular grid on the real ground. Colour: the same grid as each map draws it, after one best scale, shift and turn.
Dots: the places measured. North is up on every panel; each panel at its own scale.

Ptolemy, c. 150



2,358 places · error 12.9% · 219 km

Peutinger, c. 300



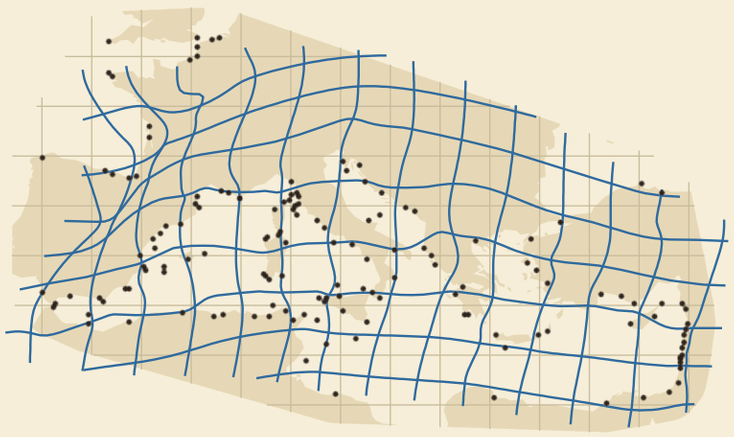
465 places · error 26.0% · 349 km

al-Idrisi, 1154



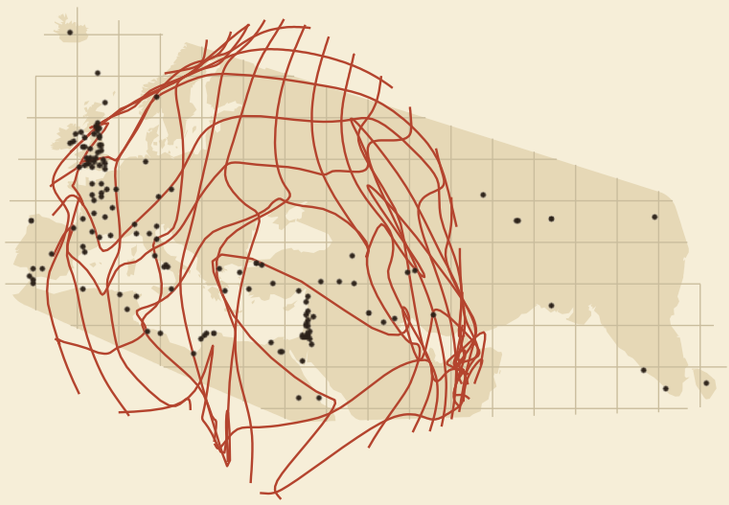
431 places · error 15.7% · 328 km

Carta Pisana, c. 1275



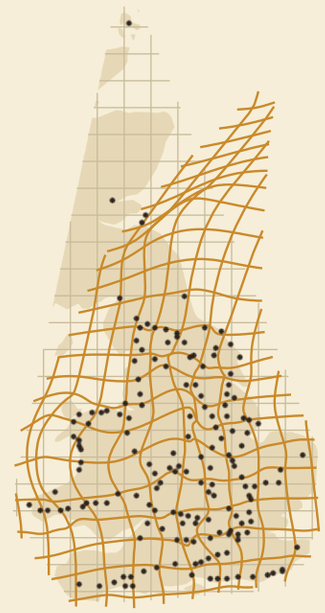
148 places · error 8.0% · 94 km

Hereford, c. 1300



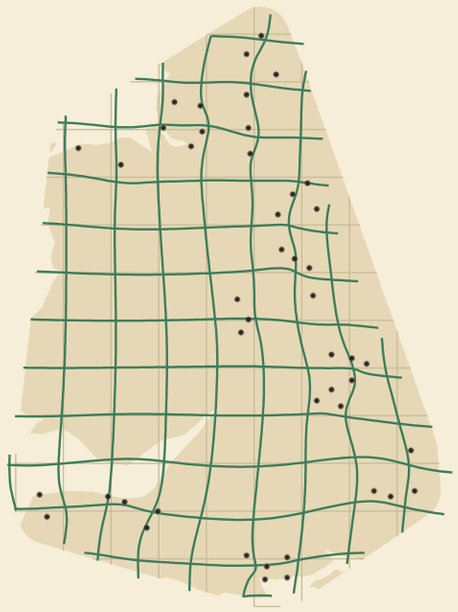
143 places · error 23.4% · 526 km

Gough, c. 1360



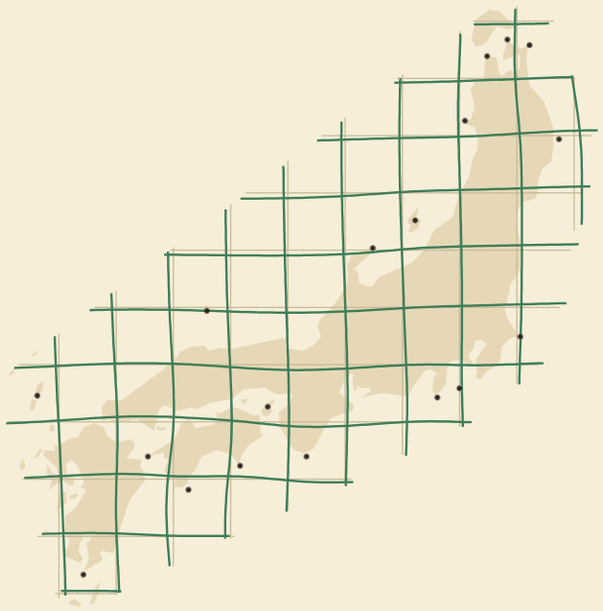
163 places · error 10.0% · 18 km

Saxton, 1579



46 places · error 3.5% · 4 km

Ino, 1821



18 places · error 1.7% · 8 km

Catalan Atlas, 1375



201 places · error 8.6% · 117 km

Data: control points from eight published studies by the author (Zenodo, CC BY 4.0); Natural Earth (public domain)
maps.tristanhotham.com/map-accuracy